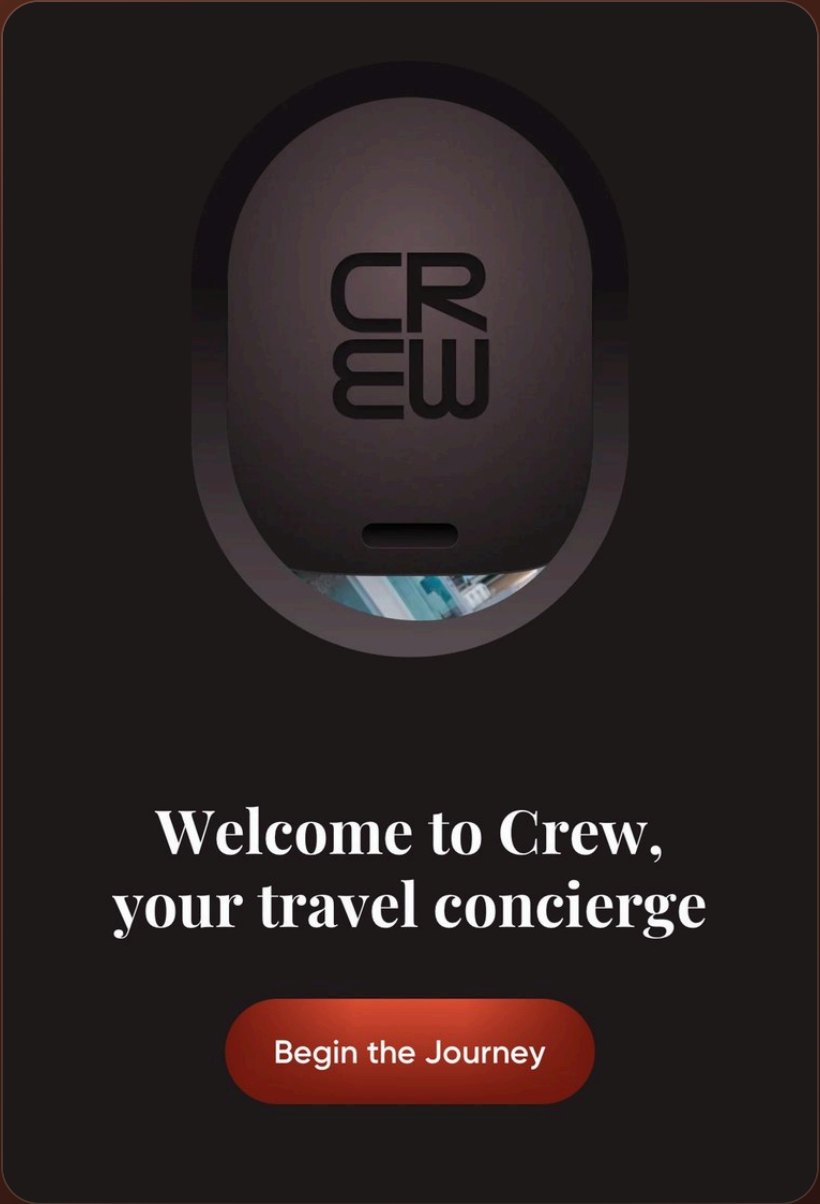


# One trip at a time.

CREW is Swiggy’s travel concierge, and it speaks before you ask. Any travel app can sell you the flight. Almost none will tell you about a terminal you have not reached yet. That message is the product. Every large platform could send it. Their economics stop them.



■ In most of the exchanges CREW publishes, CREW writes first.



# Build the plan that watches itself, and ship it before anything else

One recommendation and the three things that make it the right one. Everything after this slide is the working.

|                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| What to build                   | A trip plan the app checks against reality all day: the gate, the departure, a connection gone too tight, rain over an outdoor afternoon. When one of them breaks, the app writes the message and hands it to a person to send. |
| Because the cost is the ceiling | Swiggy already paid for acquisition and keeps the relationship warm. <b>Cost to serve is the only cost CREW did not inherit an answer to</b> , and it scales with trips rather than with the company.                           |
| Because it needs nothing new    | The plan is already a record inside trip planning. The gate and the delay are already in the booking. The forecast is free, and the tone is already written in the cards CREW publishes.                                        |
| Because it is what CREW sells   | The product is a message you did not ask for. This makes that message routine. It goes out on every trip, not only on the few where somebody thought to look.                                                                   |

# The message nobody asked for

Fifty-five minutes to catch a connecting flight, in an airport you have never been to, from a different terminal. You did not have to find that out.

## ◆ Maps the airport before you even land.

### CREW

You land in T1 but your next flight is from T2 in 55 mins. Take the inter-terminal train (8 mins) to Gate D

Thanks! Where can i grab a coffee before i board?

### CREW

Luckin coffee is right outside Gate D, try out the coconut Latte!

### Every travel app can sell the flight

Inventory and price are the two things this category competes on. You can see both before you buy. Once you have bought, they need nobody to pay attention.

### Almost none will mention the terminal

It arrives **before** landing, unprompted, with the train and how long it runs. Nothing about it is a booking.

### The absence is not an oversight

Every large platform holds the flight number, the connection and both terminals, for far more travellers. None of them has ever sent anyone a message about a gate.

CREW's own product pages. In most of the exchanges shown there, CREW speaks before the customer does.

# What I chose to improve, before choosing what to build

“Improve CREW” becomes a brief once it says for whom, and towards what. This is the brief I set myself.

|    |                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|----|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 01 | The goal             | Raise contribution margin per trip <b>without thinning the service</b> . Contribution margin is a trip’s revenue minus the cost of serving it. The same people should cover more trips, and each traveller should keep the same attention. |
| 02 | For whom             | The member who buys attention, not inventory: a first long-haul, a holiday a year in the planning, a honeymoon. The frequent flyer is out of scope.                                                                                        |
| 03 | What I read          | CREW’s public product pages and app listing, Swiggy’s own public statements, and public reporting on the concierge businesses that came before it.                                                                                         |
| 04 | What is confirmed    | The <b>₹999</b> the app asks for up front, which buys six months, and commission on what gets booked. Both are visible from outside.                                                                                                       |
| 05 | What I could not see | Whether card interchange comes back to CREW, and every internal number: headcount, retention, minutes per trip. None of it is estimated anywhere in this deck.                                                                             |

No Swiggy or CREW data was used and none was available to me. Comparable-business outcomes come from public reporting on Ten Lifestyle, Velocity Black and American Express. My own judgement starts at the options slide and is labelled from there on.

# Who this is worth paying for, and who it is not

Every exchange CREW publishes is missing the same thing. Nobody asks the price. These are CREW’s own marketing cards, so the absence is a choice, and it says who the product is for.



WORTH MOST TO · THE FIRST LONG-HAUL

## Ananya Iyer

Thirty-four, Bengaluru. This is the holiday she has planned for a year, and her first outside Asia. She knows Bengaluru street by street. She lands in Lisbon knowing nothing. Expertise does not travel with her, and one wrong call on this trip is not recoverable. What she buys is **one fewer decision.**

ONE TRIP A YEAR

NEW GROUND, HIGH STAKES

NEVER ASKS THE PRICE



WORTH LEAST TO · THE THIRTIETH FLIGHT

## Vikram Shah

Forty-one, Mumbai. The same airport again, and he knows where the lounge is. He has his own visa routine, his own hotel and his own seat. To him CREW is a nicer booking engine. **A nicer booking engine is the product whose price you check.**

FLIES MONTHLY

OWN ROUTINE, END TO END

WILL CHECK THE PRICE

Both of them fly. Only one is buying what CREW sells, and it is not the booking. Both personas are constructed from CREW’s published exchanges and from the absence in them. There were no interviews and I had no access to CREW’s customers. The portraits are illustrations, for the same reason.



# One traveller, and three jobs a booking engine cannot take



PRIMARY MEMBER • PAYING TO STOP DECIDING

## Ananya Iyer

She would rather pay for the experience than price it across five tabs. Money is only half of that. The other half is a decision she has already made: choosing is the expensive part.

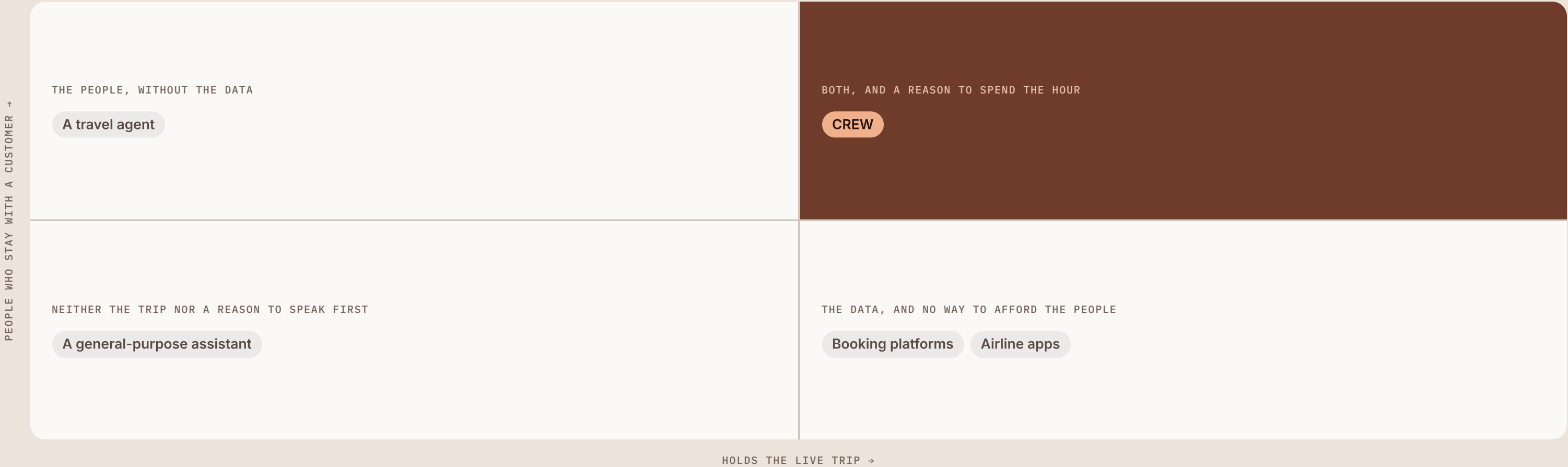
When I land somewhere I have never been, **I want to be told what happens next**, before I have worked out that I needed to ask.

When something moves — a gate, a time, the weather over the afternoon I planned — **I want to hear it from you first**, not from the airport screen.

When it is the one holiday I get this year, **I want somebody answerable**, so that being wrong is not my problem to solve at six in the morning.

# The data is not the moat

To send that airport message you need the trip and you need somebody who will stay with a customer through a day. Everybody has one of the two.



A third condition sits underneath both axes: a relationship that makes an hour on one traveller worth spending. A platform built on volume breaks when it adds a service team.

# Every standalone concierge died of the first two problems

A standalone concierge carries three costs at once. CREW inherited answers to two of them. Structure gave it those answers, not cleverness.

|                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Winning the customer | Customer acquisition cost is what it takes to win one member. Here that means finding people who travel expensively and will hand a holiday over, one at a time. The purchase is rare, so payback runs long. <b>Swiggy paid for this years ago</b> , over food and groceries, and reads its own order history to see who spends. |
| Keeping them         | Somebody travels a few times a year. A relationship that goes quiet for five months has to be rebuilt. <b>It stays warm here</b> . Instamart and Dineout keep it warm between trips.                                                                                                                                             |
| Serving them         | Cost to serve is the human minutes one trip consumes. Sitting inside Swiggy does nothing to this one. It scales with trips, not with the size of the company. <b>This is the whole rest of the deck</b> .                                                                                                                        |

It ended the same way every time: Ten Lifestyle inside private banks, Velocity Black inside Capital One, and American Express never sold its concierge separately at all. None lasted as a subscription bought on its own.



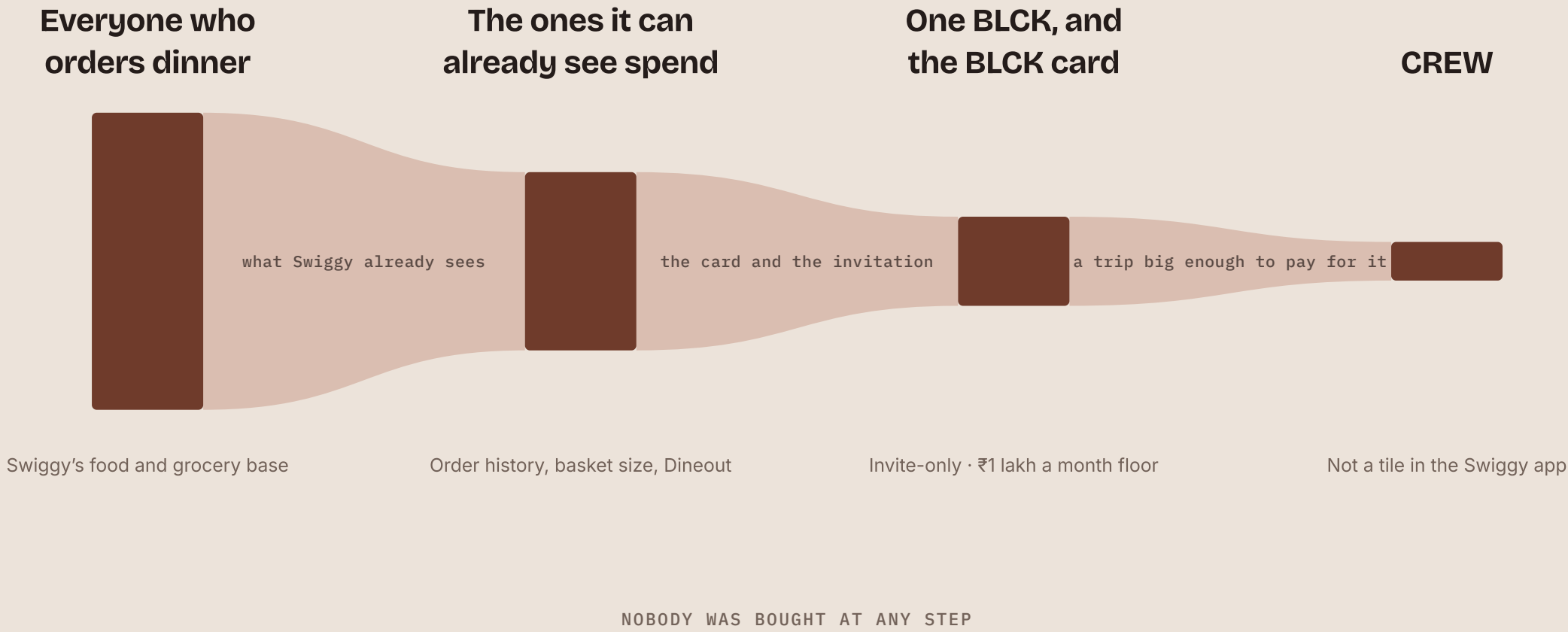
# Two lines confirmed, one I cannot see

Contribution margin is a trip’s revenue minus the cost of serving it. Acquisition and retention were paid elsewhere. That leaves the human minutes as nearly all of the cost, so the margin turns on one number.

| LINE             | WHAT IT IS                                                                                                                                               | STATUS         |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| Subscription     | The ₹999 the app asks for up front, which buys six months. Printed on the paywall, so it needs no estimating.                                            | Confirmed      |
| Commission       | A share of what gets booked. It scales with the trip rather than with the member, which is why the entrance argues about rates it earns a margin on.     | Confirmed      |
| Card interchange | The co-branded card runs spend over Swiggy plastic. Whether interchange comes back to CREW is not visible from outside, so it is not in any number here. | Not visible    |
| Cost to serve    | The human minutes one trip consumes. The only cost CREW did not inherit an answer to, and the one every proposal below attacks.                          | The constraint |

# Where a CREW member comes from

CREW is hard to find on purpose. Instamart and Dineout are tiles inside the Swiggy app. CREW is not one, because it was never built for everyone. Swiggy already owns both gates that pick the few who get it.



One BLCK is invite-only and carries a travel benefit. The co-branded HDFC card tops out in a BLCK variant, with a one lakh a month income floor and extra cashback on travel. Swiggy owns both halves: the card is the gate and the membership is the invitation. Band widths show containment, not size. No stage figure is public and none is estimated here.

THE CONSTRAINT

# The moat is the ceiling.

Swiggy scaled on physical dispatch, where a rider is interchangeable. A concierge is not. The job needs visa rules and what a connecting flight really takes. It also needs the harder half: staying calm, reading a mood, knowing when to stay quiet. A wrong burger costs a refund and an apology. A missed visa clause costs somebody their one holiday of the year.

Anything this scarce has to be rationed, and it is. CREW stays off the Swiggy app grid, and the service comes with a booking big enough to pay for it. That leaves an awkward proof: you find out whether you can hand over a trip by handing one over.

## They come through



18 May

I'm a crew addict. Here are some of the things I have gotten done. Forgot my wife's birthday present, they sent someone to Phoenix to buy something, gift wrap it and have it delivered at the restaurant before we arrived. Helped book a 15 Seater vehicle in the middle of nowhere on the outskirts of Bangalore at a moment's notice to take us to a music festival. Got me in Naru and plenty restaurants like that. A concierge service is as good as your imagination. So it's upto you to find value.

**Five stars.** One of the rare people was on this trip.

## No credibility, incomplete tasks



22 Mar

App is pretty messed up, have caused a lot of experiential and financial loses to me. - Thailand Excursion: I paid for VIP tickets but received standard service. We were seated far from the gate and lacked the promised priority boarding and speedboat transport that those with cheaper tickets received. We were told a partial refund but team never got back even on twitter. - Dhurandhar Event: Despite assurances that our group of three would be seated together in "upgraded" seats towards the back, We got seated in first 3rd row and one member of our party was seated alone across an aisle. Additionally, the team sent out public communications with incorrect event dates.- Tumi Order: In January, I paid in advance for a backpack with a seven-day delivery estimate. After a week, I was informed that the order had never actually been placed and they "forgot".- General Reliability: The team has frequently failed to secure reservations, delivered incorrect bouquets, and quoted airport transfer prices 2-3x higher than platforms like Viator or GetYourGuide

**One star.** Same service, same month.

# Four ways to move the same number

Cost to serve is minutes of a scarce person. There are only four things you can do about that, and three of them cost more than they save.

| OPTION                                          | WHAT IT DOES TO THE MINUTES                                                                                                                                                                                                              | VERDICT           |
|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Hire more concierges                            | This buys capacity at the same rate it buys cost, and budget was never the constraint. The job needs visa rules and the harder half: staying calm, knowing when to stay quiet. The supply of such people runs out before the money does. | Breaks on supply  |
| Raise the booking gate                          | This protects the margin on every trip served, by serving fewer trips. It defends the number by shrinking the business. The minutes themselves stay exactly where they were.                                                             | Wrong direction   |
| Take the person out                             | Make everything self-serve and the minutes fall to almost zero. So does the product. CREW sells somebody being answerable, and an app cannot be answerable at six in the morning.                                                        | Kills the product |
| Automate the routine, keep people for judgement | Most messages are structured data, checked against a record the app already holds. Give those to the app. The same person then covers more trips, and every traveller keeps the same attention.                                          | Chosen            |

One thing I would refuse to build: the phone call. A masseuse at a villa in Goa is not an API, and nobody has automated being the person who is answerable once something has gone wrong. The three tiers stop deliberately short of it.

# A plan that watches itself

It stands on trip planning, which already holds a trip as one record instead of a folder of bookings. Trip planning does what a traveller asks. This does the part nobody thought to ask for.



## Rewrites your day before the weather does.

CREW

High chance of rain in London, not great for Parks. Can swap it for Tate Modern - free entry, great art

Thanks, can you book us a slot for the morning then?

CREW

Done, booked you a slot at 11am to avoid the crowd. Best way to see art without the rush.

### The plan is a record

Every leg and every day already has a time against it. A few of those parts move on their own: the gate, the departure, a connection that is no longer long enough, rain over an outdoor afternoon.

### The app watches them, unasked

All day, against the record. Nobody checks these today until it is too late to move anything.

### It finds the fix and writes the message

Structured data checked against a record the app already holds. The tone is already written, in the cards CREW publishes.

### A person signs it off, in seconds

The concierge moves from producing the work to approving it. The traveller hears it from CREW first.

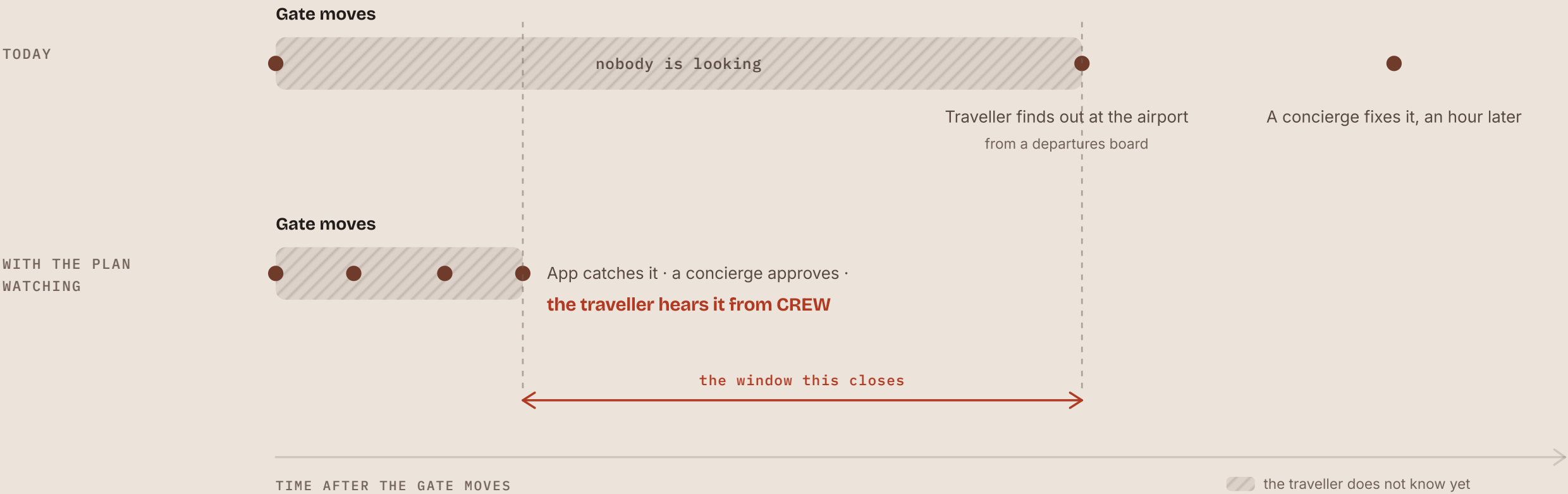
CREW's product pages show this moment as something a concierge does **when asked**. This is the same moment without the asking, on every trip rather than the few where it came up.

It asks for nothing CREW does not already have: the plan is a record inside trip planning, the gate and the delay are in the booking, and the forecast is free. Assembly, not invention.



# One gate change, before and after

The gate moves either way. The same people do the same work. What changes is the length of the window in which the traveller does not know, and who closes it — CREW, or a departures board.



The axis is ordered, not to scale. CREW publishes no timings for any of this and none are estimated here. The claim is the order of events and the direction of the change, both of which follow from where the checking happens.

# Three tiers, priced in minutes of a person

The aim is to spend the rare people only where a person is genuinely needed. Every message a member gets sorts into one of three tiers.

01

**Send it**

Routine updates, with no judgement in them. These are the plan-watching messages: structured data, checked against a record the app holds. They go out untouched. Most messages are this.

02

**Sign it off**

Anything that changes a plan or spends money. The system finds the alternative and writes the message. A concierge reads it and approves. The person stops producing the work and starts signing it.

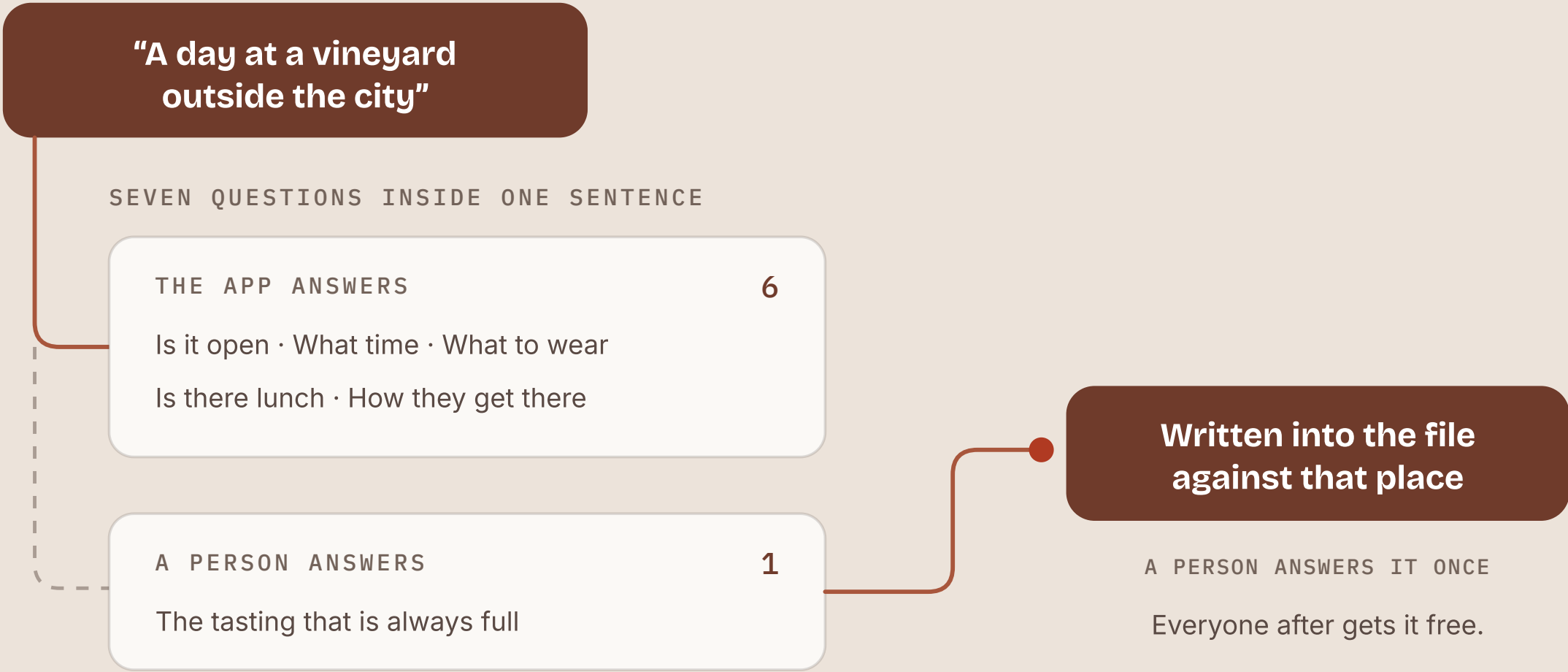
03

**Give it to  
someone who  
decides**

Everything else. A masseuse at a villa in Goa is not an API, and nobody has automated being the person who is answerable once something has gone wrong.

# One message is not one job

A request arrives as one sentence and gets worked as one job. A couple wants a day at a vineyard outside the city. Inside that sentence sit seven questions. Six already have answers. Today all seven wait for the same person.



It also compounds. When a concierge solves the one question with no answer, that answer is written down against the place: what worked, and who to call when the obvious number fails. The booking was never the output. The output was a fact nobody had recorded.

# Two numbers, and the test that would prove me wrong

Headcount alone can buy the first number, so it only means something with the second beside it.

| MEASURE                        | WHAT IT IS                                                                                                                                                                                                                | READS      |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| The let-go rate                | The share of trips where the customer could let go: no confirmation checked, no reply chased, no query about a bill that was supposed to be settled.                                                                      | North star |
| Cost to serve                  | The human minutes one trip consumes. Watch it beside the let-go rate. Minutes falling while the let-go rate climbs is the whole thesis.                                                                                   | Guardrail  |
| Both together                  | Let-go rate up and minutes down is a service running at software margins. Let-go rate up and minutes flat is quality CREW cannot afford to keep.                                                                          | The read   |
| Adoption, and the one to watch | Share of plan-watching messages sent without an edit. If concierges rewrite most of them, the app is not reading the plan properly and the tier is producing work rather than removing it.                                | Adoption   |
| What would prove me wrong      | Compare members who lean on the service against those who only book and handle the rest themselves. If both come back at the same rate, the accompaniment was never the advantage, and the honest move is to unbundle it. | Falsifier  |

THE FULL PIECE

# One Trip at a Time

Get the ceiling right and the same people cover more trips. The service holds its quality as it grows. Someone flying this route for the first time still lands knowing which train to take. The whole argument is at [ritikadas.in/writing/crew](https://ritikadas.in/writing/crew).